Chapter 10 — Responsive Design

The same page is opened on a 360px phone, a sideways tablet, a 1440px laptop and a 2560px monitor — by people who may have enlarged their default font, zoomed to 200 %, switched to dark mode, or asked the OS to reduce motion (animation can cause dizziness or nausea). **Responsive design** builds *one* page that works in all of those situations, instead of a separate "mobile site". Chapters 7–9 gave the layout tools; this chapter makes layouts **adapt**.

In this chapter: 10.1 What responsive design is · 10.2 The viewport meta tag and viewport units · 10.3 Media queries · 10.4 Mobile-first in practice · 10.5 User-preference queries · 10.6 Container queries · 10.7 Fluid typography with `clamp()` · 10.8 Responsive images recap and `image-set()` · 10.9 Intrinsic layouts · 10.10 Testing.

Every example is a page in `code/`. Screenshots in `img/` were made in headless Chrome by `code/make_figures.mjs`; the `NN_*.mjs` scripts print what the browser computed (matching queries, resolved grid columns, font sizes) using `code/measure.mjs` — as in Chapters 7–9, plus **viewport width**, **phone emulation** and **OS-preference emulation** (dark mode, high contrast…). Many screenshots are "contact sheets": one page at several widths, with the width in red above each.

10.1 What responsive design is

What it is

A **responsive** page rearranges and resizes itself to fit the **viewport** (the visible browser area) and the user's settings. Ethan Marcotte coined the term in 2010, with three ingredients:

Ingredient	Meaning	Today's tools
Fluid grids	Widths in relative units (%, `fr`, `vw`) instead of fixed pixels	Flexbox, Grid, `min()` / `max()` / `clamp()`
Flexible media	Images and videos shrink with their container	`max-width: 100%; height: auto`, `srcset`, `aspect-ratio`
Media queries	CSS that applies only under conditions ("at least 640px wide")	`@media`, and now `@container`

Why it matters

- Most web traffic is from phones; a page needing sideways scrolling or pinch-zoom loses readers.
- Google indexes the mobile version first ("mobile-first indexing"), so a broken mobile layout hurts discovery (Chapter 14).
- WCAG 2.2 requires content to **reflow** (rewrap into a narrow column without sideways scrolling) at 320 CSS px and survive 200 % text zoom (§10.10, Chapter 3).

Mobile-first vs desktop-first

	Mobile-first	**Desktop-first**
Base CSS (no query)	The phone layout	The desktop layout
Queries use	`min-width` / `width >=` — *add* features as space grows	`max-width` / `width <` — *undo* features as space shrinks
Small devices download/parse	only the rules they need, plus harmless overrides	desktop rules, then overrides to undo them
Design pressure	Forces deciding what matters most first	Tends to cram a big design into a small screen

Mobile-first is the default because the single-column phone layout is simplest — normal flow already stacks — and every larger layout is an enhancement (**progressive enhancement**: start with what works everywhere, then add).

Responsive vs adaptive: an **adaptive** site switches between a few fixed-width layouts; a **responsive** one is fluid *between* breakpoints — modern practice, with fewer breakpoints thanks to intrinsic layouts (10.9) and container queries (10.6).

10.2 The viewport meta tag and viewport units

What it is

```
<meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1">
```

This `<head>` line (Chapter 2) tells a mobile browser: "lay the page out at the device's width in CSS pixels, at 100 % zoom".

The problem it solves

When the iPhone launched (2007), sites were designed for ~1000px desktops, so mobile browsers **pretend** to be wide: without the tag they lay out in a **layout viewport** of about **980px**, then zoom out to fit. A responsive page then never sees its phone media queries fire.

A **CSS pixel** isn't a hardware pixel: at **device pixel ratio** (DPR) 3, each CSS pixel is 3×3 physical pixels; `width=device-width` = as many CSS pixels as the screen is wide (e.g. 390 on a typical modern phone).

Proof

`code/01_no_viewport.html` and `code/01_viewport.html` differ only by the tag. `code/01_viewport.mjs` opens both on an emulated 400px phone (Puppeteer's `isMobile: true` makes Chrome honour the tag like a real phone):

```
01_no_viewport.html  layout 980px, visible 980px, scale 0.408, font-size 16px
01_viewport.html     layout 400px, visible 400px, scale 1, font-size 16px
```

Without the tag the page is scaled by 400 / 980 ≈ 0.408 — "16px" text is really about **6.5px**.



Figure 10.1 — The same page on a 400px phone, without and with the viewport meta tag.

The values

Key	Typical value	Notes
`width`	`device-width`	Layout viewport = screen width in CSS px. A number (`width=600`) is rarely right.
`initial-scale`	`1`	Start at 100 % zoom; also stops iOS changing zoom on rotation.
`maximum-scale`, `user-scalable=no`	**don't**	Blocking zoom fails WCAG 1.4.4 (Resize text); iOS Safari has ignored `user-scalable=no` since iOS 10 for this reason.
`viewport-fit`	`cover`	Notched phones (camera cut-out); then pad with `env(safe-area-inset-*)` (browser-supplied unsafe-edge sizes).

Viewport units

`vw` / `vh` are 1 % of the viewport (Chapter 6). On phones the height **changes** as the address bar slides, so CSS Values 4 added three variants (Baseline since December 2022):

Unit	1% of…	Behaviour on a phone
`svh` / `svw` (small)	the viewport with toolbars **shown**	never too tall; may leave a gap when toolbars hide
`lvh` / `lvw` (large)	the viewport with toolbars **hidden**	may be hidden behind toolbars at first
`dvh` / `dvw` (dynamic)	the viewport **right now**	follows the toolbars; can cause relayout while scrolling
`vh` / `vw` (classic)	in practice the **large** viewport on mobile	why `height: 100vh` "overflows" on phones

Use `min-height: 100svh` (always fits) or `100dvh` (tracks the toolbar) for full-screen heroes and the §8.7 sticky footer; `vw` for fluid type (10.7), never alone — it ignores zoom settings. On desktop all four heights are equal. Also: `vi` / `vb` (inline/block direction), `vmin` / `vmax`.

Common mistakes

- Forgetting the tag: every phone breakpoint silently fails.
- Disabling zoom "to feel like an app" — an accessibility failure.
- `width: 100vw` with a vertical scrollbar: on desktop `100vw` *includes* the scrollbar, so the element is ~15px too wide → sideways scrolling. Use `width: 100%`.

10.3 Media queries

What it is

A **media query** is a condition about the device or environment; rules inside `@media (condition) { … }` apply only while it's true, re-evaluated live (rotation, resize).

```
@media screen and (width >= 40em) { .cards { grid-template-columns: repeat(2, 1fr); } }
```

Media queries add no specificity; normal cascade rules apply (Chapter 6) — so mobile-first queries go **after** the base rules they override (equal specificity → later wins).

Where you can use them

Place	Example
CSS at-rule	`@media (width >= 40em) { … }`
`<link>`	`<link rel="stylesheet" href="print.css" media="print">` — still downloaded, but not render-blocking when it doesn't match
`@import`	`@import url(wide.css) (width >= 64em);`
`<source>` in `<picture>`	`<source media="(width >= 800px)" srcset="wide.jpg">` (Chapter 4)
JavaScript	`matchMedia('(width >= 64em)')`

Anatomy

1. **Media type** (optional): `all` (default), `screen`, `print`. Others (`tv`, `handheld`…) are deprecated.
2. **Media features** in parentheses: `(width >= 40em)`, `(orientation: landscape)`, `(hover: hover)`.
3. **Logic**: `and`; comma = **or**; `not` negates a whole query (or, in Level 4 syntax, a condition: `not (hover: hover)`); `only` is a legacy guard — harmless, unneeded.

Media features you'll actually use

Feature	Values / example	Use
`width` (+ `min-` / `max-`)	`(width >= 40em)`	Layout breakpoints (viewport width)
`height`	`(height < 500px)`	Short landscape phones: shrink sticky headers
`orientation`	`portrait` | `landscape`	Rarely needed — width says more
`aspect-ratio`	`(aspect-ratio >= 16/9)`	Full-screen media layouts
`hover` / `any-hover`	`hover` | `none`	Show hover-reveal UI only when the *primary* (or *any*) pointer can hover
`pointer` / `any-pointer`	`fine` | `coarse` | `none`	Larger tap targets for touch (`coarse`)
`resolution`	`(resolution >= 2x)`	High-DPR assets (prefer `srcset` / `image-set()`)
`prefers-color-scheme`	`light` | `dark`	Dark mode (10.5)
`prefers-reduced-motion`	`reduce` | `no-preference`	Tone down animation (10.5, Chapter 12)
`prefers-contrast`	`more` | `less` | `custom` | `no-preference`	Stronger borders/colours
`forced-colors`	`active` | `none`	Windows High Contrast / contrast themes
`print` (type)	`@media print`	Hide nav, show link URLs, black on white

Range syntax (Media Queries Level 4)

Comparison operators replace `min-` / `max-`. Baseline since March 2023, *widely available* since September 2025 (Chrome 104, Firefox 102, Safari 16.4).

Old	Range syntax
`(min-width: 640px)`	`(width >= 640px)`
`(max-width: 639.98px)`	`(width < 640px)`
`(min-width: 640px) and (max-width: 1023.98px)`	`(640px <= width < 1024px)`

Why `.98`? With `max-width: 639px` and `min-width: 640px`, a 639.5px window (possible with zoom or fractional DPR) matches **neither**; range syntax's `<` removes the gap.

`em` or `px` for breakpoints?

In media queries `em` / `rem` are always relative to the **browser's default font size** (normally 16px), *not* your `html { font-size }` (even `62.5%`). So `40em` = 640px by default, but 800px for a user with a 20px default — the layout goes single-column earlier, exactly what large-text users need. Both units work; `em` ties breakpoints to text size.

Choosing breakpoints

Let the **content** decide — widen the window until it looks wrong and add a breakpoint *there*; device lists go stale. Aim for two or three layout breakpoints plus intrinsic techniques (10.9) and container queries (10.6). Reference: Tailwind `sm 640 · md 768 · lg 1024 · xl 1280 · 2xl 1536`; Bootstrap 5 `576 · 768 · 992 · 1200 · 1400`.

Media queries in JavaScript

`window.matchMedia(query)` returns a `MediaQueryList` with `.matches` and a `change` event — for behaviour CSS can't express (swap a component, pause a carousel). Don't listen to `resize` and compare `innerWidth`; `change` fires only when the answer flips (`addListener()` is the deprecated older form).

```
const desktop = matchMedia('(width >= 64em)');
desktop.addEventListener('change', e => console.log(e.matches ? 'desktop' : 'not desktop'));
```

10.4's output shows it: resizing 400 → 900 → 1100 → 1300 → 700 fired exactly **two** events.

Common mistakes

- Mixing desktop-first `max-width` and mobile-first `min-width` queries — overlaps and gaps. Pick one direction.
- A media query **before** the base rule it should override.
- `(hover: hover)` alone to guess "desktop": touchscreen laptops and phones with mice exist.
- Breakpoints for specific devices ("iPhone 15") instead of content.

10.4 Mobile-first in practice

The page

`code/02_mobile_first.html` is a small travel page: base styles are the phone layout; two `min-width`-style queries add columns. The red badge (a `::after` whose `content` each query overrides) shows the active rule set.

```css
/* Base = phone: single column; normal flow + grid gap does the stacking */
.layout { display: grid; gap: 14px; padding: 14px; }
.cards  { display: grid; gap: 10px; }

@media (width >= 40em) {                    /* 640px: tablets, small laptops */
  header { display: flex; justify-content: space-between; align-items: center; }
  .cards { grid-template-columns: repeat(2, 1fr); }
}
@media (width >= 64em) {                    /* 1024px: sidebar appears */
  .layout { grid-template-columns: 1fr 240px; max-width: 1200px; margin-inline: auto; }
  .cards  { grid-template-columns: repeat(3, 1fr); }
}
```

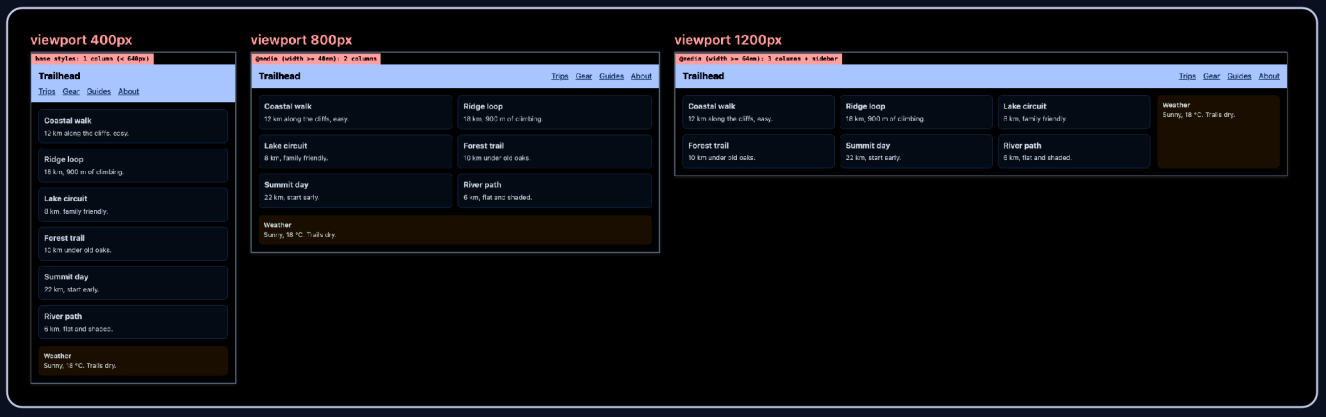


Figure 10.2 — One page, three widths. The HTML never changes; only which rules apply.

`code/02_media_queries.mjs` — matching queries and the resolved card grid:

```
 400px  (width >= 40em) no   (width >= 64em) no   cards: 372px
 800px  (width >= 40em) yes  (width >= 64em) no   cards: 381px 381px
1200px  (width >= 40em) yes  (width >= 64em) yes  cards: 299.328px 299.328px 299.344px
matchMedia events: [ 'change -> desktop at 1100px', 'change -> not desktop at 700px' ]
```

By hand at 1200px: 1200 − 2 × 14 padding = 1172; − 240 sidebar − 14 gap = 918 for `.cards`; − 2 × 10 gaps = 898; ÷ 3 = **299.33px**. ✓

Why it works

- **Normal flow** is already mobile-first: blocks stack, so the base CSS barely lays out.
- Each query **adds** a layout; nothing is "undone".
- **DOM order** (header, cards, aside) is the reading order at every width, so keyboard and screen-reader users get the same sequence (Chapter 3). Visual reordering with `order` or grid placement breaks that.

Responsive navigation (common pattern)

At phone width a long nav usually becomes a **menu button**: a real `<button aria-expanded="false" aria-controls="menu">` (telling screen readers whether the menu is open and what it controls) toggling the list with a few lines of JS, or the Popover API (`popover` attribute, Baseline since January 2025) for a no-JS disclosure. With few links, the demo's flex-wrap nav is simplest.

Responsive tables

Data tables can't reflow into one column without losing meaning. Wrap them in a scroll container — `<div class="table-wrap" tabindex="0" role="region" aria-label="Prices">` with `.table-wrap { overflow-x: auto; }`; WCAG allows two-dimensional scrolling for data tables (Chapter 5).

10.5 User-preference media queries

What it is

OS settings for dark theme, reduced motion or more contrast are exposed to CSS by the **user-preference media features** (Media Queries Level 5):

Feature	Baseline	Typical use
`prefers-color-scheme: dark`	widely available (2020)	Dark theme
`prefers-reduced-motion: reduce`	widely available (2020)	Remove or soften animation — Chapter 12
`prefers-contrast: more`	widely available (2022)	Solid borders, stronger colours
`forced-colors: active`	widely available (2022)	Windows contrast themes replace your colours: let system colours win, keep visible borders/focus on custom controls (system colours like `CanvasText`, `ButtonText`), don't rely on background images for meaning
`prefers-reduced-transparency`	**not** Baseline (Chromium only)	Remove frosted-glass effects
`prefers-reduced-data`	not supported anywhere yet	—

Dark mode — the essentials

1. **Declare support**: `<meta name="color-scheme" content="light dark">` and/or `:root { color-scheme: light dark; }`. The browser then themes its **own** UI — default background and text colour, form controls, scrollbars — even with no other dark CSS, and avoids a white flash. (`color-scheme`: Baseline 2022.)
2. **Colour tokens** (named values like `--bg`) as custom properties (§6.9), light values first.
3. **Override the tokens** in `@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark)`; components use only tokens.
4. One-off values: `light-dark(lightValue, darkValue)` picks by the element's **used colour scheme** (what `color-scheme` and the user's setting finally decide) — no media query, but `color-scheme: light dark` must be set. Baseline since May 2024 (newly available).

```
:root { color-scheme: light dark;
        --bg: #ffffff; --text: #1f2937; --card: #eff6ff; --accent: #1d4ed8; --border: #bfdbfe; }
@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) {
  :root { --bg: #0f172a; --text: #e2e8f0; --card: #1e293b; --accent: #93c5fd; --border: #334155; }
}
@media (prefers-contrast: more) { :root { --border: currentColor; } }

body  { background: var(--bg); color: var(--text); }
.note { color: light-dark(#92400e, #fcd34d); }
```

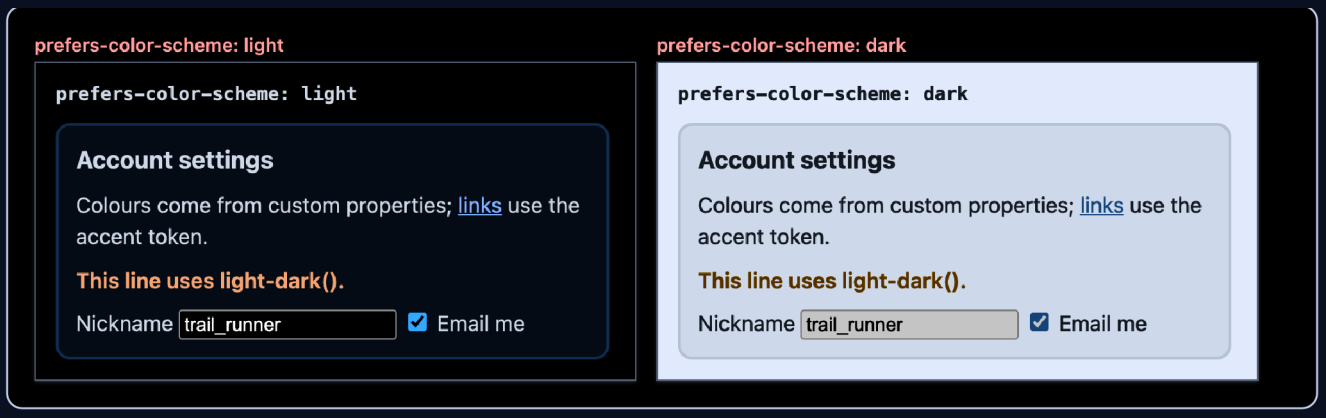


Figure 10.3 — `code/03_preferences.html` under emulated light and dark. Nobody styled the input and checkbox — `color-scheme` made the browser draw dark versions. Reproduce the dark shot with `node tools_web_shot.mjs chapters/10-responsive-design/code/03_preferences.html out.png 420 --dark`.

`code/03_preferences.mjs` reads computed colours under three emulated settings:

```
light (default)        bg rgb(255, 255, 255)  text rgb(31, 41, 55)  card border rgb(191, 219, 254)  note rgb(146,
64, 14)  <input> bg rgb(255, 255, 255)
dark                   bg rgb(15, 23, 42)  text rgb(226, 232, 240)  card border rgb(51, 65, 85)  note rgb(252,
211, 77)  <input> bg rgb(59, 59, 59)
light + more contrast  bg rgb(255, 255, 255)  text rgb(31, 41, 55)  card border rgb(31, 41, 55)  note rgb(146, 64,
14)  <input> bg rgb(255, 255, 255)
```

With more contrast the border became the text colour (`currentColor`); `rgb(59, 59, 59)` is Chrome's built-in dark control colour. Gotcha: headless Chrome follows the **computer's** theme when nothing is emulated, so on a dark-mode Mac a `color-scheme: light dark` page screenshots dark — `measure.mjs` emulates `light` explicitly.

Letting users override

A theme toggle sets `data-theme="dark"` on `<html>` and stores the choice; tokens are defined for `[data-theme="dark"]` too, and the media query applies only when no choice was made (`:root:not([data-theme="light"])`). Full architecture, with `color-scheme` per theme: Chapter 13.

Designing a dark theme well

- Don't invert: dark greys/navies (pure `#000` with pure white text causes halation — a glowing halo around letters), lighter accents, contrast re-checked ≥ 4.5:1 (Chapter 11).
- Shadows barely show on dark backgrounds — show elevation with slightly lighter surfaces.
- Dim very bright photos (`filter: brightness(.9)`) or supply dark versions with `<picture><source media="(prefers-color-scheme: dark)" …>`.

Reduced motion in one rule

```
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {
  *, *::before, *::after { animation-duration: 0.01ms !important; animation-iteration-count: 1 !important;
                           transition-duration: 0.01ms !important; scroll-behavior: auto !important; }
}
```

A common blunt reset; §12.9 covers the gentler "motion only when allowed" pattern and WCAG's requirements.

10.6 Container queries

What it is

A **container query** (`@container`) styles an element by the size of an **ancestor container** instead of the viewport. Baseline since February 2023, **widely available** since August 2025 (Chrome 105, Firefox 110,

Safari 16).

The problem it solves

A product card sits in a wide main column, a narrow sidebar and a two-up grid — on one screen. A media query only knows the *viewport*, so it can't tell them apart; you used to hand-add modifier classes (`.card--compact`). With container queries the card adapts to the space **it is given** ("how big is my box?", not "how big is the room?").

How it works

1. Mark an ancestor as a **size container**: `container-type: inline-size` (width only — the usual choice) or `size` (both axes; then the container can't get its height from content, so give it one). Shorthand `container: name / type` adds an optional **name**.
2. Write rules in `@container [name] (condition) { … }`; they apply to **descendants** of the matching container.
3. For each element the browser finds the **nearest ancestor** container (with that name, if given) and tests **its** content-box size.
4. A container can't style *itself* by its own query (circular), so the demo puts the container on a wrapper (`.card-slot`) and styles the `.product` inside.

```
.card-slot { container: card / inline-size; }       /* name "card", measured inline */

.product    { display: grid; gap: 8px; }             /* base: picture above text */
.product h3 { font-size: clamp(15px, 3cqi + 8px, 24px); }

@container card (width >= 400px) { .product { grid-template-columns: 160px 1fr; } }
@container card (width >= 600px) { .product { grid-template-columns: 240px 1fr; padding: 16px; } }
```

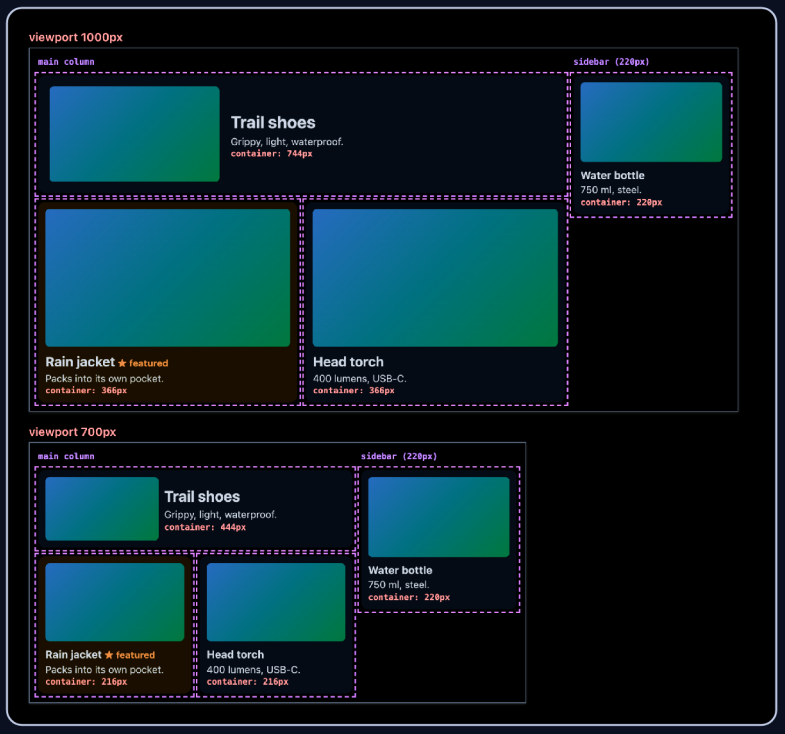


Figure 10.4 — code/04_container_queries.html. Dashed purple = containers; each card prints its container width. Same component, same viewport, three layouts.

Output of code/04_container_queries.mjs :

```
viewport 1000px
  Trail shoes   container 744px  columns 240px 456px    h3 24px      ::after none
  Rain jacket   container 366px  columns 346px          h3 18.98px   ::after " ★ featured"
  Head torch    container 366px  columns 346px          h3 18.98px   ::after none
  Water bottle  container 220px  columns 200px          h3 15px      ::after none
viewport 700px
  Trail shoes   container 444px  columns 160px 256px    h3 21.32px   ::after none
  Rain jacket   container 216px  columns 196px          h3 15px      ::after " ★ featured"
  Head torch    container 216px  columns 196px          h3 15px      ::after none
  Water bottle  container 220px  columns 200px          h3 15px      ::after none
```

The sidebar card (220px) is identical at both widths, while "Trail shoes" switches from the ≥600px to the ≥400px layout — impossible with a media query.

Container query units

Unit	1% of the query container's…
`cqw` / `cqh`	width / height
`cqi` / `cqb`	inline size / block size (writing-mode aware — prefer these; a 500px container → `10cqi` = 50px)
`cqmin` / `cqmax`	smaller / larger of the two

With no suitable container they fall back to **small viewport** units (`svw` / `svh` / `svi` …). Check: `clamp(15px, 3cqi + 8px, 24px)` in 366px = 3 × 3.66 + 8 = **18.98px** ✓; in 220px = 14.6 → clamped to **15px** ✓; in 744px = 30.3 → capped at **24px** ✓.

Style queries

`@container style(--featured: yes)` tests a **custom property's computed value** on the nearest container instead of its size; every element is a style container, so no `container-type` is needed. In the demo `.featured { --featured: yes; }` turns "Rain jacket" yellow with a star — a design-token switch with no modifier class. **Baseline since May 2026** (newly available: Chrome 111, Safari 18, Firefox 151), custom properties only (`style(display: flex)` is unsupported) — treat as an enhancement for now.

Other container queries (not Baseline)

`scroll-state()` queries ("is this sticky header stuck?", "is this carousel item snapped?") are Chromium-only (Chrome 133+).

Container queries vs media queries

Use a **media query** for…	Use a **container query** for…
Page-level layout (how many columns the page has)	Components that appear in different-sized slots
User preferences (`prefers-*`), print, pointer type	A card/widget's internal layout
Anything about the device	Text/spacing relative to the component (`cqi`)

They combine: media queries shape the page; container queries let each piece adapt to the space it got.

Common mistakes

- `container-type` on the element you want to restyle — it only restyles **descendants**.
- `container-type: size` without an explicit height: collapses to 0, because size containment (sizing the box as if empty) ignores its content.
- `inline-size` containment means the container's **width** can't depend on its children — inside a shrink-to-fit parent (a `flex: none` item, inline-block, float) it may collapse. Give it width from outside (grid track, block flow, `flex: 1`).

- An unnamed `@container (width > 400px)` matches the **nearest** size container of any name — name containers in design systems.

Fallback for older browsers

```
@supports not (container-type: inline-size) { .product { /* a sensible single layout */ } }
```

`@supports (feature: value)` is a **feature query**: rules apply only if the browser understands the declaration. Needed now only for old devices.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "Media queries respond to the viewport; container queries respond to an ancestor I declared a container with `container-type: inline-size`. That makes components portable: the same card stacks in a sidebar and sits side-by-side in the main column on one screen. A container can't query itself, so I put it on a wrapper, and use `cqi` for sizes relative to it. Size queries are Baseline since 2023; style queries on custom properties became Baseline in 2026."

- *Why not `container-type: size` by default?* → Size containment stops its size depending on content; for height that usually collapses it to 0. `inline-size` only removes the width dependency.
- *Drop media queries?* → No: page layout and user preferences still belong to media queries.

10.7 Fluid typography with `clamp()`

What it is

Fluid typography makes font sizes (and often spacing) change **smoothly** with the viewport between a minimum and maximum, instead of jumping at breakpoints. The tool is `clamp(MIN, PREFERRED, MAX)` = `max(MIN, min(VAL, MAX))` — Baseline since 2020, with `min()` and `max()`.

How to derive the formula

Goal: **16px at a 320px viewport → 24px at 1200px**.

1. **Slope** = Δsize / Δviewport = (24 − 16) / (1200 − 320) = 8/880 = 0.00909 → **0.909vw** (1vw = 1 % of the viewport).
2. **Intercept** (size at 0px) = 16 − 0.00909 × 320 = 13.09px = **0.818rem**.
3. Preferred value `0.818rem + 0.909vw`, clamped to `1rem … 1.5rem`:

```
:root {
  --step-0: clamp(1rem, 0.818rem + 0.909vw, 1.5rem);      /* 16px → 24px  */
  --step-3: clamp(1.75rem, 1.296rem + 2.273vw, 3rem);     /* 28px → 48px  */
  --space:  clamp(0.75rem, 0.341rem + 2.045vw, 1.875rem); /* 12px → 30px  */
}
p  { font-size: var(--step-0); }
h1 { font-size: var(--step-3); }
```

(Another: 18px at 400px → 22px at 1400px: slope 4/1000 = 0.4vw, intercept 16.4px → `clamp(1.125rem, 1.025rem + 0.4vw, 1.375rem)`.)

`code/05_fluid_type.mjs` compares Chrome's computed sizes with the formula:

```
slope = 0.909vw, intercept = 13.091px = 0.818rem
  280px  p 16.00px (by hand 16.00)   h1 28.00px
  320px  p 16.00px (by hand 16.00)   h1 28.01px
  600px  p 18.54px (by hand 18.55)   h1 34.37px
  900px  p 21.27px (by hand 21.27)   h1 41.19px
 1200px  p 24.00px (by hand 24.00)   h1 48.00px
 1600px  p 24.00px (by hand 24.00)   h1 48.00px
default font 20px, viewport 1000px, rem + vw (ours)  -> 25.45px
default font 20px, viewport 1000px, vw only (bad)    -> 16px
```

The 0.01px differences come from rounding coefficients to three decimals.



Figure 10.5 — code/05_fluid_type.html at three widths, printing its own computed sizes.

Why the `rem` part is essential (accessibility)

The last two lines emulate a user with a 20px **default font size**: `rem + vw` grows to 25.45px (0.818 × 20 + 9.09); pure `vw` stays **16px** — ignoring the setting and not growing with page zoom as users expect. WCAG 2.2 SC 1.4.4 (Resize text) needs text to scale to 200 %: keep a `rem` term in the preferred value, `MIN` / `MAX` in `rem`, and MAX/MIN at or below about 2.5 so zoom still enlarges text meaningfully. (`clamp(1rem, 2vw, 1.5rem)` works, but between its limits it ignores the user's setting.)

Type scales

A **modular scale** is font sizes related by one multiplier (each step = previous × ratio, e.g. 1.2 "minor third" on small screens, 1.333 "perfect fourth" on large). Fluid type interpolates each step linearly between its small- and large-screen size — what `--step-0 … --step-5` token sets from generators like Utopia do. The same works for spacing (`--space`).

Common mistakes

- `font-size: 4vw` alone — unreadable on phones, huge on monitors, ignores user settings.
- `clamp(16px, …, 24px)` — px limits ignore the user's default; prefer `rem`.
- Forgetting `line-height`: large headings need a smaller unitless line-height (a plain multiplier, 1.1–1.2), body ~1.5 (Chapter 11).

10.8 Responsive images recap (and `image-set()`)

Full coverage in §4.3: `img { max-width: 100%; height: auto }` plus `width` / `height` attributes (no layout shift); `srcset` with `w` + `sizes` (browser picks by slot width and DPR) or `1x` / `2x` (fixed size, sharper on high-DPR); `<picture>` + `<source media>` for **art direction** (a different crop per width) or `<source type>` for a newer format with fallback; `aspect-ratio` to hold a box's shape before content loads.

`image-set()` for CSS background images

`srcset` only works on `<img>`. For **background images** use `image-set()` — Baseline since September 2023, widely available since March 2026 (older Safari needed `-webkit-image-set()`):

```
.hero {
  background-image: url("media/hills-400.jpg");                /* fallback */
  background-image: image-set("media/hills-400.jpg" 1x,
                              "media/hills-800.jpg" 2x);
  background-size: cover;
}
```

Candidates can also be chosen by format: `image-set("a.avif" type("image/avif"), "a.jpg" type("image/jpeg"))`. `code/06_image_set.mjs` loads `code/06_image_set.html` at three pixel ratios and logs the network:

```
devicePixelRatio 1: downloaded hills-400.jpg
devicePixelRatio 2: downloaded hills-800.jpg
devicePixelRatio 3: downloaded hills-800.jpg
```

Only **one** file per screen. A background image is decoration: meaningful pictures need `<img alt>` (the demo's `role="img"` + `aria-label` exist only because it demonstrates a decorative technique).

10.9 Intrinsic layouts — responsive without breakpoints

What it is

Intrinsic design (Jen Simmons' term) lets the browser's layout algorithms respond to available space themselves, using `min()`, `max()`, `clamp()`, `flex-wrap`, `auto-fit` and `minmax()`. Fewer breakpoints → fewer awkward in-between widths, and components that work in any container.

Three patterns

`code/07_intrinsic.html` — no `@media` anywhere:

```css
/* 1. Readable centred column: at most 60ch, and never touching the screen edges */
.wrapper { width: min(100% - 2rem, 60ch); margin-inline: auto; }

/* 2. Sidebar that wraps when the content would get narrower than 60% */
.with-sidebar          { display: flex; flex-wrap: wrap; gap: 10px; }
.with-sidebar > .side  { flex: 1 1 150px; }                    /* wants ~150px */
.with-sidebar > .content { flex: 999 1 0; min-inline-size: 60%; } /* takes the rest */

/* 3. Card grid: as many ≥140px columns as fit (Chapter 9 §9.3) */
.grid { display: grid; gap: 10px; grid-template-columns: repeat(auto-fit, minmax(min(140px, 100%), 1fr)); }
```

Pattern 2: the content's huge `flex-grow` (999) takes almost all free space, keeping the sidebar near 150px. When the line can't hold `150px + gap + 60%`, flex-wrap moves the sidebar to its own full-width line — a "breakpoint" chosen by content, working in any container.



Figure 10.6 — The same page at 360px and 1000px.

`code/07_intrinsic.mjs` :

```
 360px  wrapper 328.0px | sidebar wrapped above content | grid 2 column(s)
 480px  wrapper 448.0px | sidebar beside content (150.3px + 287.7px) | grid 3 column(s)
1000px  wrapper 529.1px | sidebar beside content (150.3px + 368.8px) | grid 3 column(s)
```

By hand at 480px: wrapper = min(480 − 32, 60ch ≈ 529px) = 448px; the line needs 150 + 10 + 0.6 × 448 = 428.8 ≤ 448, so the sidebar stays beside; free 448 − 10 − 150 = 288 shared 1 : 999 → sidebar 150.3px ✓. At 360px the wrapper is 328px and the line would need 356.8px, so it wraps ✓.

Other intrinsic tools

- `flex-wrap: wrap` + `flex: 1 1 12rem` — a button row that becomes a column when needed (Chapter 8).
- `max-inline-size: 65ch` on text — the **measure** (line length) that reads best (Chapter 11).
- `aspect-ratio` placeholders + `object-fit: cover` (Chapter 11).

When not to use it

When the design genuinely changes structure (a sidebar becoming a bottom tab bar), a media query states that intent more clearly than a flex trick.

10.10 Testing responsive design

What to test

Check	How	Pass criterion
No sideways scrolling	Resize from 320px to 1920px+	`scrollWidth ≤ clientWidth` at every width (except data tables, maps, etc.)
Reflow (WCAG 2.2 SC 1.4.10, AA)	View at 320 CSS px wide (= 1280px at 400 % zoom)	All content and functions with vertical scrolling only
Resize text (SC 1.4.4, AA)	Browser zoom 200 %; also raise the default font size	No clipped or overlapping text
Text spacing (SC 1.4.12, AA)	Line-height 1.5, paragraph spacing 2em, letter 0.12em, word 0.16em	Nothing clipped — avoid fixed heights on text boxes
Target size (SC 2.5.8, AA, new in 2.2)	Inspect tap targets	At least 24 × 24 CSS px (or enough spacing)
Orientation (SC 1.3.4)	Rotate the device	Works in both, unless essential
Touch vs mouse	Real phone; `(hover: none)`	Nothing reachable *only* on hover
Preferences	Emulate dark, reduced motion, forced colours	Readable, no lost UI

Tools

- **DevTools device mode**: Chrome/Edge and Firefox Ctrl/Cmd+Shift+M; Safari Responsive Design Mode (Develop menu). Drag the width slowly to find breaking widths. Chrome's Rendering panel emulates `prefers-color-scheme`, `prefers-reduced-motion`, `forced-colors` and more; Elements shows a `container` badge for inspecting container queries.
- **Real devices**: emulators don't reproduce touch precision, the dynamic toolbar (`dvh`), the on-screen keyboard or real CPU speed. Test at least one Android phone and one iPhone via remote debugging (Chrome `chrome://inspect`, Safari Web Inspector).
- **Automated screenshots and checks** in CI with Puppeteer or Playwright, like this chapter's scripts.

An automated overflow test

`code/08_overflow_check.mjs` opens pages at 320/768/1280px, compares `scrollWidth` with the viewport's `clientWidth`, and lists elements whose `getBoundingClientRect().right` sticks out (or whose content overflows its box):

```
08_broken.html          320px  OVERFLOW (page is 575px wide): div.promo, img, p
```

Every other page/width combination (`02_mobile_first` , `08_fixed` , and `08_broken` at 768/1280px) reports `ok` .



Figure 10.7 — The three most common causes of sideways scrolling on phones, and their one-line fixes.

Bug in `08_broken.html`	Fix in `08_fixed.html`
`.promo { width: 500px }`	`max-width: 500px` — fixed widths are the #1 cause
`<img width="480">` with no CSS	`img { max-width: 100%; height: auto; }`
Long URL with no break opportunities	`overflow-wrap: anywhere` (or `break-word`) on text containers

Other culprits: `100vw` widths (10.2), `1fr` grid columns that can't shrink below a long word (`minmax(0, 1fr)` , §9.10), flex items with `min-width: auto` (Chapter 8), `<pre>` blocks and wide tables (wrap in `overflow-x: auto`).

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "I build mobile-first: base CSS is the single-column phone layout and `min-width` queries add columns where the content needs them. The viewport meta tag makes phones lay out at device width. Intrinsic techniques — flex-wrap, `repeat(auto-fit, minmax())` , `clamp()` fluid type with a `rem` term — keep breakpoints few, and container queries handle components in different-sized slots. I respect `prefers-color-scheme` with `color-scheme` , and `prefers-reduced-motion` . Images use `srcset` / `sizes` . I test in device mode, on real phones, at 320px and 200 % zoom for WCAG reflow."

- *Why does `100vh` misbehave on mobile?* → It equals the large viewport (toolbars hidden), so with toolbars visible the bottom is cut off. Use `svh` or `dvh` .
- *How do you pick breakpoints?* → Where the content breaks, not device widths; `em` so they follow the user's font size.
- *How do you avoid horizontal scrolling?* → No fixed widths (`max-width`), flexible media, `overflow-wrap` , `minmax(0,1fr)` , and an automated check at 320px.
- *What can't DevTools device mode emulate well?* → Real touch, dynamic toolbars/ `dvh` , the on-screen keyboard, real performance.

Chapter 10 TL;DR

- **Responsive** = fluid layout + flexible media + conditional CSS. Build **mobile-first**: base CSS is the phone layout; `(width >= …)` queries add columns.
- **`<meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1">`** — without it phones lay out at ~980px and shrink (scale 0.408 on a 400px phone). Never disable zoom.

- **Viewport units**: `svh` (toolbars shown), `lvh` (hidden), `dvh` (live); `vh` ≈ `lvh` on phones; `100vw` includes the scrollbar.
- **Media queries**: type + features + `and` / `,` / `not`. Range syntax `(640px <= width < 1024px)` is widely available and removes boundary gaps. `em` in queries = browser default font size. JS: `matchMedia(q)` + `change` event.
- **Preferences**: `prefers-color-scheme` + `color-scheme: light dark` (themes form controls too) + token overrides; `light-dark()` (Baseline 2024); `prefers-contrast`, `forced-colors`, `prefers-reduced-motion`.
- **Container queries** (widely available since Aug 2025): `container: name / inline-size` on a wrapper, `@container name (width >= 400px)` for descendants, `cqi` units. Style queries on custom properties: Baseline 2026. Scroll-state queries: Chromium only.
- **Fluid type**: `clamp(MIN, a·rem + b·vw, MAX)`; slope = Δsize/Δviewport, intercept = size − slope × viewport; keep a `rem` term so user settings and zoom work (vw-only stayed 16px with a 20px default).
- **Images**: `max-width: 100%`, `srcset` / `sizes`, `<picture>`; `image-set()` for backgrounds (one file per DPR).
- **Intrinsic layouts**: `min(100% - 2rem, 60ch)`, flex-wrap sidebar, `repeat(auto-fit, minmax(min(X,100%),1fr))` — breakpoints chosen by content.
- **Test**: 320px reflow, 200 % zoom, text spacing, 24px targets, real devices, dark/reduced motion, automated overflow checks.

Next: Chapter 11 — Typography, Colour and Visual Effects.